Calderwood Estates — Annual Facilities Report

1. Boiler Plant Replacement

The boiler plant replacement programme cost 4.7 million pounds and completed in November. Three gas-fired units were removed from the basement plant room and replaced with condensing equivalents. The contractor worked outside teaching hours throughout, so no sessions were lost to the works. Flue routing was rebuilt to discharge above the parapet, which required a scaffold licence for eleven weeks. Commissioning ran across two weekends and the system was rebalanced afterwards. The old units were removed by a licensed recycler and their copper recovered. Warranty runs for seven years from handover. Plant room lighting and ventilation were renewed at the same time because the space was already stripped, which the surveyor recommended.

2. Lift Maintenance

Eleven passenger lifts and two goods lifts are covered by a single maintenance contract renewed each April. Engineers attend monthly for planned servicing and are called out on demand. Mean time between callouts across the estate was 214 days, which the contract sets as the reliability floor. Door sensors account for the largest share of faults, followed by controller boards. Two lifts in the east wing are approaching the end of their design life and a condition survey is scheduled. Spares are held on site for the two most common failures to avoid waiting on delivery. Out-of-hours attendance is guaranteed within four hours and has been met on every occasion this year.

3. Window Replacement Programme

The window replacement programme continued across the residential blocks this year. Single-glazed timber frames are being replaced with double-glazed aluminium throughout, block by block, so that residents move out for one week rather than a whole term. Acoustic performance was specified alongside thermal, because the north elevation faces the bypass. Scaffolding is shared between adjacent blocks to reduce hire costs. Waste frames are separated on site and the glass recycled separately from the timber. The programme is funded from the capital reserve rather than from operating budgets. Across the year 1,340 window units were replaced.

4. Grounds and Security

Grounds maintenance contracts total 890,000 pounds annually, covering mowing, hedging, tree surveys and winter gritting across the whole estate. The contractor holds an arboricultural qualification, which the tree stock requires. Gritting is triggered by a forecast threshold rather than by observation, so the routes run before dawn. Security is provided by a separate contractor under its own agreement. The gatehouse is staffed continuously and mobile patrols cover the outer car parks between dusk and dawn. Camera coverage was extended to the western boundary after a spate of thefts from vehicles. Access cards are issued by the estates office and deactivate automatically when a contract ends.

5. Catering and Waste

The catering contract was retendered this year and awarded for five years with a break at three. Three outlets operate daily during term and one continues through vacations. Menu costing is reviewed quarterly against commodity indices. Waste is collected under a separate arrangement, and the estate diverted 71 percent of its waste from landfill. Food waste is separated at source in all three kitchens and goes to anaerobic digestion. Dry mixed recycling is collected twice weekly and general waste once. Confidential paper is shredded on site under a witnessed process. The waste contractor reports tonnages monthly and these feed the annual sustainability return.

6. Parking and Signage

Parking on the estate is managed by permit, with allocation weighted toward staff who work irregular hours or carry equipment. Enforcement is contracted out and appeals are heard by an independent panel. The two largest car parks were resurfaced this year and their drainage renewed at the same time. Wayfinding signage was replaced across the whole estate to a single specification, which took most of the summer vacation. Fingerposts at the three main entrances now carry building numbers rather than department names, because departments move and buildings do not. The signage scheme cost 156,000 pounds.

7. Estates Overview

The estates directorate employs 268 people across maintenance, grounds, security, catering, portering and administration. The estate comprises 44 buildings over 31 hectares, with a gross internal area of 186,000 square metres. Operating expenditure was broadly flat against the prior year once energy is excluded. Capital projects completed on schedule in all but one case, where a planning condition delayed a start. Statutory compliance was maintained across all disciplines with no enforcement action. Staff turnover in the directorate fell for the second successive year. The service desk logged 41,200 requests, of which 94 percent were closed within target. Tenant satisfaction was surveyed in the spring.

8. Year in Summary

Capital projects completed on time and within the approved envelope. Energy consumption fell after the boiler works and the lighting retrofit landed together. The service desk handled a higher volume than last year with the same establishment. The estate's insured reinstatement value is assessed at 412 million pounds, revalued this year for the first time since the pandemic. Compliance inspections were completed across all disciplines. Grounds and security contracts were both retendered without dispute. Portering absorbed the additional load from the two building moves without agency cover. The directorate closed the year within budget on both pay and non-pay.

9. Director's Statement

This has been a year of consolidation rather than expansion. The directorate absorbed two significant capital programmes while keeping the routine service running, which is a credit to the teams involved. Recruitment remains difficult in the trades, and we continue to rely on a small number of long-serving staff whose knowledge is not written down. The compliance position is sound and was independently verified. Energy remains the largest single exposure and the hedge expires next year. Relationships with the two principal contractors are constructive. Looking ahead, the condition survey will set the capital programme for the next cycle. Deferred maintenance across the estate now stands at 23.8 million pounds.

10. Plant Room Condition

The plant rooms were surveyed for condition and access this year. Boiler housings, pipework lagging and pump mountings were inspected in each of the four rooms. Several runs of lagging were found damaged where cabling had been pulled through, and these were made good. Access to the west plant room remains poor and a permanent ladder is specified for next year. Ventilation grilles were cleared and the louvre actuators serviced. Water treatment dosing was recalibrated on all circuits. Expenditure on plant room works sits within the routine maintenance budget and is not separately reported. The survey did not price any replacement of the boilers themselves.

11. Landscape and Planting Strategy

The landscape strategy sets out how the grounds are managed over a ten year horizon. Mowing regimes were relaxed on three verges to encourage wildflowers, and the resulting reduction in cutting frequency was agreed with the contractor. Tree stock is surveyed on a three year cycle and high-risk specimens annually. Replacement planting favours native species and follows the loss of eleven mature trees to disease. Hedging along the northern boundary is being restored by laying rather than flailing. The strategy does not set contract values, which are handled separately through procurement.

12. Workforce and Recruitment

Recruitment across the directorate remains difficult in the trades, particularly for mechanical and electrical craftspeople. Vacancies are advertised continuously rather than in campaigns. Agency use rose slightly in portering and fell in cleaning. An apprenticeship scheme started with four places across maintenance and grounds. Retention improved following the pay review, and exit interviews now cite commute and shift pattern more often than pay. Long service is a feature of the workforce and a succession risk. Training days were taken up more fully than last year. Establishment figures are held by human resources and are not reproduced in this section.